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A timeline of Nolan Wells' disappearance, death and the unfolding investigation

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By [Danya Gainor](#)



Nolan Xavier Wells, the 18-year-old who died on an island off the coast of Mississippi while on a ...

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In the days since the puzzling death of an 18-year-old, investigators have undertaken a painstaking effort to reconstruct the events that unfolded on Horn Island, a remote barrier island about 10 miles off the Mississippi coast.

The investigation has unfolded rapidly since Nolan Wells disappeared on the Fourth of July from the island he was visiting with high school friends. While those friends returned to the mainland, Wells’ body was found days later in the water.

Now, the search for answers extends well beyond the remote island.

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As public interest escalates, investigators are working to piece together Wells’ final hours while his family continues to press for transparency and answers. The young man’s death has stoked speculation and distrust in part due to Mississippi’s fraught racial history and the fact that Wells appeared to be the only person of color in an image with friends on the trip.

Here’s a timeline of key developments in the case and where the investigation stands.

A familiar trip to a remote island

Wells graduated in 2025 from Ocean Springs High School in the coastal Mississippi town of Ocean Springs, just east of Biloxi. He then enrolled in Southwest Mississippi Community College, where he was a wide receiver on their football team, according to The Associated Press.

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On the evening of **July 3**, the teen made his family salmon for dinner before leaving to spend the night with his friends ahead of the holiday weekend.

“It was hug, kiss, and he left,” Christine Wonsley, his mother, said.

And like countless Americans across the country, Wells set out to mark the July Fourth holiday on the water.





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He joined his friends for a boat trip to Horn Island – a federally protected barrier island known for its untouched beaches, shifting shoreline and quiet isolation. It wasn't uncommon for Wells to visit the island with friends, according to his family.

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Wells was supposed to return to school after the holiday weekend to start training for the upcoming football season, his father Elmore Wonsley said in an interview with “Good Morning America.”

In photos from the boat that day, the 18-year-old towers above his friends, his arm casually slung around their shoulders as he smiles for the camera.



Nolan Wells is pictured with his friends on a boat during the Fourth of July. (*Jackson County Sheriff's Department*)

But by the time the group returned to the mainland that afternoon, a day that began as a holiday celebration took an unsettling turn: Wells was not with them. His family reported him missing the night of **July 4**, after they received a phone call around 11 p.m. from one of his friends.

What followed was an intense search effort that would soon end tragically.

Hope gives way to a widening search

As the first hours passed without answers, Wells' mother turned to social media, sharing desperate appeals for information about her son's whereabouts. In a post on the morning of **July 5**, Christine Wonsley said she and her husband had possession of their son's cellphone and that they'd traveled to the island to search for him.

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Tashema Hands, the mother of one of Wells' friends, retrieved the phone for the family after tracking it using Snapchat to a house where "a lot of people" were gathered, Hands told CNN's Laura Coates, adding it took about 15 minutes for someone to find the phone and give it to her.

Wonsley said when she went through her son's phone, it struck her as "too clean" because there were no videos or pictures in Snapchat from the day he was on the island.

“I know my child well ... if he has a phone out all the time at home, he’s definitely going to have a phone out whenever he’s out and he’s doing things with his friends,” she told Coates. “So that was just really hard to believe that there was nothing there.”

The worried mother posted photos she was given of Wells on the night of July 5, which she said were taken during the July 4 boat trip. The teen, at 6’1”, smiles for the camera in blue swim trunks and sunglasses.

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That day, the Jackson County Sheriff’s Department publicly announced they were coordinating with the United States Coast Guard and Mississippi’s Department of Marine Resources to search the island.



State law enforcement conducts search operations for Nolan Wells in Jackson County, Mississippi.
(WLOX)

Sheriff John Ledbetter would later tell the AP: “From the people we’ve talked to, it sounds like he chose to stay on the island with the assumption that he was going to ride back to the mainland with someone else.”

But Jayvon Williams, one of Wells’ friends who had seen him on the island on July 4, said that account doesn’t square with the person he knew. “I’ve never known Nolan to stay back while his friends leave,” he told CNN. “He’s always been a guy where if he rode with you, he’s going to come back with you. That’s always how he’s been every single time.”

Wells' family has also said they "can't fathom" why he would separate from his group of friends. "We always taught him, 'If you go with a group, you stay with the group,'" his father said.

As Christine Wonsley's social media appeals gained traction online, several groups joined the search for Wells, including the United Cajun Navy, a nonprofit volunteer search and rescue group based in Louisiana.

The group's vice president told CNN he spoke to several people who were at Horn Island on July 4 and described the beach as being packed with boats and people, some of whom had been drinking alcohol.

If someone had fallen into the water, Brian Trascher said, strong rip currents that day may have posed a risk.



The United Cajun Navy helped search for Nolan Wells by air. *(United Cajun Navy)*

The case shifts from missing person to death investigation

Writing to her growing social audience on **July 6**, Christine Wonsley said the family has "so many questions. Our hearts are breaking, we keep waiting for Nolan to walk through that door with his beautiful smile and a joke of course."

“We pray our son is alive & safe,” she wrote.

But hours later, the search for Wells ended with the news his family had feared most. A body matching Wells’ description was recovered from the water near the shoreline, officials said.

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There were no immediate signs of physical injury, Jackson County Coroner Bruce Lynd told CNN. The coroner’s office requested that the autopsy be conducted at the state medical examiner’s office because of the “condition” in which Wells’ body was found and to definitively determine whether there was any trauma or foul play, Lynd said.

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Officials are still awaiting test results, including toxicology, before determining a cause of death, according to Lynd.

But underneath the anticipation, skepticism was mounting online over the accounts of Wells’ final hours with his friends and statements from police.



Law enforcement searched for Nolan Wells in Jackson County, Mississippi, before his body was discovered on July 6. (WLOX)

A family seeks answers as scrutiny mounts

A statement from the sheriff on **July 6** that “no foul play was suspected” in Wells’ death seemed to only fuel frustration and anger on social media.

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Many have looked at the photos of Wells, where he appears to be the only young Black man in group pictures, and sensed danger – a reminder of Mississippi’s fraught racist past many argue is still alive today.

Others have taken to social media to post about their own experiences of being the only person of color in predominantly White spaces, and the challenge that can bring.

The Wells family retained civil rights attorney Ben Crump on **July 7** to represent them as the investigation into his death continues. Crump said he has not spoken to the young men who were traveling with Wells because they have obtained legal representation.



Elmore Wonsley consoles his wife Christine Wonsley during a news conference on July 10, 2026.
(David Dee Delgado/Reuters)

The sheriff’s department on **July 8** acknowledged the speculation circulating on social media but noted “investigators are working to establish the facts through eyewitness accounts, physical evidence, and other reliable information.”

At a news conference on **July 10**, Christine Wonsley said the sheriff’s statements also gave the family pause.

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A small video thumbnail showing a man in a suit and tie speaking. The video title is "Attorney for Nolan Wells' family says current explanation 'just doesn't add up'" and the duration is "4:27".

“I do absolutely respect law enforcement,” she said, but “the accidental drowning thing, it made both me and his father uncomfortable. Why are we so quick to rush to this?”

“What we’re wanting is transparency,” she said. “At the end of the day, we want answers.”

Crump said the family requested an independent autopsy be performed because “it is not adding up.”

“We had his body flown from Mississippi to Washington, DC, because his family wanted to make sure that they had a doctor who had no ties to Mississippi law enforcement to do an independent examination of their son’s body,” he said.

Those results are expected “very soon,” Crump said on **July 11**.

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Wells’ parents and their attorneys met with Jackson County District Attorney Angel Myers McIlrath on **July 15**. They said they did not learn of new information about the investigation but agreed to have a “mutual inspection” of Wells’ cell phone done by experts from each party.



Horn Island, a Mississippi Gulf Coast barrier island south of Ocean Springs, Mississippi, as seen on May 21, 2025. *(Barbara Gauntt/Clarion Ledger/USA Today Network/Imagn Images)*

A case still unresolved

More than a week after Wells disappeared from Horn Island, many of the central questions surrounding his final hours remain unanswered, including why he didn't return on the boat with his friends or have his cellphone with him.

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Investigators have specifically asked for original, unedited photos and videos taken on July 4, "particularly those depicting alleged altercations or containing images of, or believed to include Nolan Wells."

"Right now, I know time is of the essence, but folks want answers ten minutes ago, and unfortunately, that takes time to get the accurate information ... It's gonna take a lot of hard work," Ledbetter, the sheriff, told CNN affiliate WXXV.

Authorities say they are also investigating online reports of an alleged altercation on the island on July 4 and whether it involved Wells.

In one video recorded near the island on July 4 and widely circulated on social media after Wells' death, someone can be heard yelling as if in a heated argument. One of Wells' friends later said it was his voice not Wells' on the video.

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"In that video, you hear somebody yelling — that is me," Tracestin Shepherd told Rolling Stone.

Wells' parents said they are pushing through their grief to figure out what happened to their son.

"At the end of the day, I would hope any parent would fight for their kids to find out if anything happened," Christine Wonsley said.

A GoFundMe launched for Wells' family to pay for his funeral expenses says he will be "forever loved. Forever remembered. Never Forgotten."



Nolan Wells' father, Elmore Wonsley, holds a news conference with family attorney Ben Crump and Rev. Al Sharpton after Wells' death over the 4th of July weekend. *(Steve Sanchez/Sipa USA)*

Some public figures have also stepped up to help cover the family's expenses. Civil rights activist and former football player Colin Kaepernick helped fund the independent autopsy, while filmmaker Tyler Perry will be covering funeral expenses, according to Crump.

Funeral services have been scheduled for **July 20**. Wells' mother described the gathering as a "home going celebration" for her son, which will include a party for friends and family at the Jackson County Fairgrounds.

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"He would not want us to be sitting around crying and eating, so what we are going to do is kind of have a party to celebrate him," Wonsley said.

Horn Island remains much as it was before, surrounded by water and shaped by the tides.

But for Wells' loved ones, that island where the budding football star often spent time represents something new entirely: a search for answers. They are still waiting to understand what happened to Nolan, a son, a teammate and a friend whose life

stretched far beyond the island where it ended.

CNN's Hanna Park, Chelsea Bailey, Ryan Young, Jason Morris, Elizabeth Wolfe, Holly Yan and Sydney Bishop contributed to this report.

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